

Stories for Success: Narrative Persuasion about Government Agencies in Kenya and the United States

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Abstract

Much of the work on democratic communication focuses on what facts citizens learn about the government, but *how* citizens interpret information can be equally important. I test one mode of shifting audience perception while holding information constant: storytelling. I argue that narratives with an exposition-climax-resolution format increase empathy towards government representatives and create more positive affect towards institutions. I test this using stories about three agencies in two countries. Observational data from a Kenyan police department that posts case stories on Twitter shows that more “story-like” narratives garner more positive replies. Survey experiments in Kenya and the U.S. show that telling a story about a contentious decision by police, the DMV, or a fire department increases empathy and trust towards officials – including beliefs that officials were honest – compared to straightforward presentations of the same information. This ability to build trust through careful presentation has important implications for democratic accountability.

There are many ways in which information is used to shape public opinion about governments. While autocracies often rely on outright false information as propaganda to sustain a regime (e.g. Guriev and Treisman, 2015), democracies cannot fabricate information in the same way. However, democratic governments still rely on public trust in order to function (e.g. Warren, 2018) and trust in democracies has been steadily declining.¹ While existing studies often focus on the accuracy of the information provided in public communication (e.g. Nyhan et al., 2020), the ideology represented (e.g. de Benedictis-Kessner, 2021), or contrast different

¹e.g. per Pew Research, Public Trust in Government 1958-2025. [link](#)

approaches to a topic (e.g. Gross, 2008), governments are “not as concerned about whether certain facts are reported but [are] more concerned about how these facts will be interpreted” (Rozenas and Stukal, 2019). Therefore, democratic governments may turn to other forms of persuasion and propaganda in order to build public trust, that don’t rely on manipulating the content of information but instead how it is interpreted.

I test one method of political communication wherein the style of communication could shape how facts are interpreted: storytelling. I argue that telling a story versus a more straightforward version of the same facts can persuade an audience to trust the government representatives and institutions depicted. Despite a wealth of research on the emotional reactions elicited by stories, they have not been studied as a means of communication by and about the government.

Both narratives, which detail some events and characters, and episodic frames, which focus on individual experiences rather than overarching patterns, have been shown to be consistently persuasive, regardless of whether they are fictional or drawn from real experiences. This rests on a variety of mechanisms and moderators, including how entertaining and emotionally provocative they are (Aarøe, 2011; Bilandzic and Busselle, 2013). However, across these literatures, experiments either hold structure constant and vary content (such as perspective (Hoeken, Kolthoff and Sanders, 2016) or topic (Paluck and Green, 2009)) or vary both, by comparing a personal narrative to more straightforward facts (e.g. Hart, 2011; Gross, 2008; Morris et al., 2019; Wojcieszak and Kim, 2016). In contrast, I define a story as being determined by its structure – starting with exposition, moving through events in sequence, and ending with the resolution. This both aligns with what we recognize as a story, and underlies many of the persuasive mechanisms such as showing events in context (Ritivoi, 2016) and withholding the resolution to build emotions (Barraza and Zak, 2013). As such, even when information is held constant, a story should be more persuasive than other structures of information.

While I expect that telling a story, by this strict definition, should be persuasive, there are several additional factors which may moderate any persuasion effects. Narratives are less effective when they originate from sources audiences are skeptical of (Escalas, 2007) or are on issues they are invested in (Bilandzic and Busselle, 2013). This may be a problem for

government stories, as positive government communications are seen as less credible (James and Van Ryzin, 2017) and particularly when from institutions from which citizens are at risk of harm (Bannister and Connolly, 2011). Additionally, as part of the effectiveness of stories rests on entertainment and emotion, less interesting stories may not be persuasive. Finally, there is some evidence that the attribution of responsibility in narratives varies by communal versus individualistic societies (Boukes, 2022); as such the country context may matter for how audiences update on the characters depicted.

To answer these questions, I test whether telling a story about government representatives rather than a more straightforward recital of the same facts increases trust in the government. Increasing trust in government is not necessarily a normatively “good” outcome, but it is one that is important to understand. The ability to shape technically true information into a more persuasive format that generates more support for government figures has important implications for democratic accountability. While the effects of censorship and misinformation can at times be countered with factual information (e.g. Chen and Yang, 2019), it is less clear how to disabuse a positive public opinion shaped by storytelling. Stories are also more entertaining, leading them to reach a wider potential audience than more standard government communication. Despite fears about direct misinformation, misleading but true information has been shown to spread more widely and impact opinions more (Allen, Watts and Rand, 2024). Further, entertaining media engages a wider audience than straightforward reporting and results in enduring shifts in political preferences (Kim, 2025).

I present results from two studies, one in Kenya that leverages both observational and experimental data and one in the United States that leverages experimental data. The overall conclusion is consistent: telling a story versus a more straightforward version of the same facts effectively persuades an audience to trust government representatives. This holds despite varying baselines institutional trust, individual experiences with institutions, entertainment level of the stories, and country context.

In Kenya I focus on the Directorate of Criminal Investigations (DCI), which began sharing stories of their cases on Twitter in a stated effort to build public trust. There is a long history

of police abuse in Kenya, contributing to the difficulty of building trust in the police (Torney-Purta, Barber and Richardson, 2004; Levi and Stoker, 2000). Further, though the last ten years have seen attempts at reform among the Kenyan police, reform is often insufficient to undo the effects of bad experiences with government (Morris, 2021; Palmer, 2024).

I leverage the DCI communications campaign in two phases. First, I show that followers of the DCI as opposed to other police accounts become more positive in posts about the police only after the DCI account becomes active. Further, within the case narratives shared by the DCI, those related in a “story” structure generate more positive replies. Interviews conducted by the author in Nairobi with the DCI and others involved in police reform indicate this campaign has also led to a real life increase in information shared by the public and public trust.² Second, I adapt one of the cases from the DCI Twitter to test the causal claim that story structure increases trust in the police, using a hard test case wherein a suspect was killed by the police. I find that those who read a story vignette as opposed to a more straightforward version which contains the same facts are more likely to trust the police officers have and will make the right decisions, and that they are telling the truth about the case described.

To test whether these findings generalize across government institutions and country contexts, I ran a second survey experiment on a representative sample in the United States. I developed vignettes based on real public communications from representatives of a DMV and a fire department, again depicting a controversial decision and holding the facts constant but varying the structure of the vignettes. The DMV is generally a disliked and boring institution, while fire departments are well liked and have more interesting and high-stakes incidents. In both cases, participants who read the story were more likely to say that the government representatives made the right decisions and will continue to do so in the future. They were also more likely to say representatives had good intentions, were telling the truth, and were representative of the institution as a whole.

This paper makes several contributions to the existing literature. I directly test the idea of story structure rather than content as driving persuasion. Though there has been reason

²A summary of the interviews and interview procedures is in Appendix A

to believe that a story arc generates a particular response (e.g. Zak, 2015), past studies have provided facts, an alternate story, or at times nothing as a potential control. This project seeks to hold information constant and test directly the effects of telling a story with that information. For instance, all vignettes in this project would be considered as an episodic frame (Iyengar, 1994), but only some are a story by my definition. This serves to separate the idea of “storytelling” from other strategies of persuasion, such as perspective taking. I also benchmark the effects of storytelling against a known generator of trust, procedural justice, to gauge the magnitude of the effects.

Second, I test the efficacy of storytelling as originating from a government, across multiple agencies and country contexts. The effects were consistent, whether I examined agencies plagued by ongoing violence and corruption, agencies that are boring and disliked, or agencies that are generally celebrated. I discuss the normative implications of these findings at the end of the paper.

Finally, I also test for evidence of the mechanisms underlying the persuasive effect of storytelling on trust. I show support for a mix of mechanisms that contribute to persuasion and have been theoretically connected to the effectiveness of stories at persuasion: an increase in anxiety, increased empathy for the main characters, more absorption in the vignette, and a difference in how participants update their opinions based on the same pieces of information. These mechanisms may help explain why stories are sometimes hard for an audience to identify as potential manipulation.

The paper proceeds in four sections. First, I summarize the literature on persuasion and storytelling to outline the features and conditions under which stories may be an effective mode of persuasion. Second, I detail the Kenya case study, discuss the context in which these real-life stories of police behavior operate, and present both observational and experimental results that show the stories can be effective persuasion. Third, I turn to the U.S. case study, which both replicates the experimental results and demonstrates how results vary depending on the government institution being described. The final section concludes.

Stories as a Mechanism for Persuasion

Much of political communication research focuses, rightly, on the content of what is communicated to the public and how they react. Although definitions of propaganda often encompass government communication broadly, our focus is often on the content, such as falsifying the competence of leaders (Guriev and Treisman, 2015) or coopting identity markers to build support (Bleck and Michelitch, 2017), and the information environment, such as the presence of opposition media (Ananyev et al., 2019) or the flooding of official channels with distracting content (Roberts, 2018). However, there is evidence that the mode in which information is communicated matters, to increase attention or understanding (Ferraz and Finan, 2008) but also to alter the interpretation of information (Rozenas and Stukal, 2019). One approach to change how people react to the same information is to tell a story.

Stories are one of the oldest and most accessible forms of communication. In fact, stories have been shown to be more effective than straightforward facts at, for instance, changing behaviors to be more pro-social (Morris et al., 2019), increasing the reporting of corruption in Nigeria (Blair, Littman and Paluck, 2019), increasing dissent in Rwanda (Paluck and Green, 2009), and facilitating intergroup reconciliation in Rwanda, Burundi, and the DRC (Bilali and Staub, 2017). It has long been theorized that the stories citizens hold in their minds play the largest influence on their interpretation of political events, over the direct facts (Lippmann, 1922). However, even though stories are often and increasingly used by governments and their representatives, such as the documented increase of stories in political speeches (Gooch, 2018), they are rarely studied as a means of shifting opinions about government. Further, prior work on storytelling takes a broad definition of a story, in experimental work most often defined as a personal anecdote in comparison to a set of facts (e.g. Morris et al., 2019; Wojcieszak and Kim, 2016; Krause and Rucker, 2020; De Wit, Das and Vet, 2008) . These are not *wrong*, but vary both the content and structure of information, making it difficult to parse what is driving effects.

I define stories as a subset of personal narratives, distinct based on telling events using a

particular structure: exposition, an inciting incident followed by rising action, climax, falling action, and resolution. I focus on structure for three reasons. First, the “dramatic arc” builds suspense and tension and is linked with observable increases in cortisol and oxytocin (Zak, 2015). This process is associated with increases in anxiety, empathy, and pro-social behaviors, including trust in other people (Barraza and Zak, 2013). Indeed, anxiety about how events will play out and what will happen to actors has been shown to make people less likely to rely on standing pre-dispositions and therefore more willing to change their beliefs, even if it means accepting claims from a group viewed as the opposition (Arceneaux, 2017).

Second, the arc of a story corresponds with so-called “narrative transportation” whereby people become absorbed in a story (Escalas, 2007). As an audience is absorbed in a story, the information is processed emotionally rather than logically, and therefore can minimize “reactance, resistances, or counterargument” (Bilandzic and Busselle, 2013). Rather than interrogating the validity of facts, the logic being presented, or comparing it against known priors, narrative transportation can distract an audience from a weak argument (Escalas, 2007).

Third, a story shows events in the context and sequence they occur. This too contributes to empathy as an audience learns about actions and decisions in sequence without knowledge of the outcome (Ritivoi, 2016). In general, personal narratives are more effective at changing opinions than other types of narratives (Gooch, 2018). However, as a story enables narrative transportation, shows events in the order and context they occurred, and presents a given personal lens, an audience is more likely to identify with the protagonist in a story, regardless of their preexisting alignment with characters (De Graaf et al., 2012). This identification leads to individuals being more likely to use motivated reasoning, for instance if they believe a character lived up to moral values, then they too feel as though they have morally succeeded. This increases the persuasive ability of a story relative to the protagonist (Carpenter, 2019).

Many of these features and patterns overlap with the work on episodic framing. Episodic framing is defined as “a case study or event-oriented report [that] depicts public issues in terms of concrete instances” (Iyengar, 1994). Much like the work on storytelling, the majority of experimental work has contrasted such case studies with broader pictures of overall issue

(often referred to as thematic framing) (e.g. Ciuk and Rottman, 2021; Hart, 2011; Bas and Grabe, 2015). Similar to the findings on storytelling, episodic framing is also associated with greater emotional engagement (Gross, 2008), more attention and recall (Bas and Grabe, 2015; Aarøe and Petersen, 2020), greater moral conviction or satisfaction (Ciuk and Rottman, 2021), and more willingness to change attitudes (Gross, 2008; Aarøe, 2011). My definition of what constitutes a story is a subset of a episodic frame. Given multiple personal narratives, all would be defined as a episodic frame while which one is labeled a story depends on the structure.

Storytelling and Trust

Much of the literature on institutional trust focuses on trust as a consequence of government performance or service provision (Mishler and Rose, 2001; Levi and Stoker, 2000; Campbell, 2004). As such, communication that highlights features of institutions such as procedural justice – that officers follow tenets of neutrality, fairness, and respecting the voice of citizens – consistently increases trust in law enforcement (Turner et al., 2011). In essence, if citizens learn that there are strong institutional checks on performance and ethical standards for members, this enables trust (Warren, 2018; Bannister and Connolly, 2011).

However, there is evidence that perceptions of government shape how performance is evaluated, rather than the other way around (Hudson, 2006; Hetherington, 1998; Franklin, Van der Eijk and Marsh, 2012; Putnam, Leonardi and Nanetti, 1992), creating incentives to change public perception rather than behavior. Further, institutional reform is both slow moving and, even when successfully undertaken, not always successful at improving the relationships between citizens and the government or undoing any consequent effects on the willingness to engage with institutions or representatives (Morris, 2021; Palmer, 2024). Therefore, storytelling might provide a means to manipulate perceptions of competence and generate empathy for members of an institution and thereby increase trust.

Further, none of the characteristics which aid storytelling as a means of persuasion rely on a story being fictional – instead I classify a story by the structure of information. Therefore,

it may be an attractive form of communication in democracies, where accountability mechanisms make out-and-out propaganda more difficult. While autocracies can directly manipulate information to falsify competence (Guriev and Treisman, 2015) or reduce overall reliability of information and therefore anything against a regime (Edmond, 2013), this is less possible in most democracies. Moreover, even when propaganda is an option, it is often most effective when undetectable (Roberts, 2018; King, Pan and Roberts, 2017). Storytelling offers a method to share technically true information in a format that can manipulate the reaction of the audience, i.e. it changes how information is processed rather than what individuals are learning, while being relatively undetectable as a manipulation.

Expected Effects of Stories

Given this, I expect that audiences who read a story will be more likely to trust and have a positive affect towards the government officials depicted, as compared to reading the same information in a different form. However, there are reasons to think this may vary based on several features.

Beliefs are least flexible when people are personally involved (Murphy and Shleifer, 2004), and narratives can induce reactance when subjects are invested in the issue (Bilandzic and Busselle, 2013) or skeptical of the source (Escalas, 2007) and are therefore more likely to notice and criticize weak arguments. Further, information from governments which depicts high performance is seen as less credible (James and Van Ryzin, 2017). Therefore, stories may be less effective when audiences have direct, negative experiences with the institutions depicted (Levi and Stoker, 2000), particularly when they risk harm by engaging (Bannister and Connolly, 2011). Past work on storytelling in contexts such as post conflict resolution has occurred when there is no active dissonance between life and the story – stories about institutions with ongoing issues may generate additional skepticism.

Additionally, since entertainment and engagement is a main mechanism (Escalas, 2007), and narratives and episodic frames have only been more effective than facts when they are able

to generate emotion from an audience (Aarøe, 2011), stories which are about less interesting institutions or incidents may be less effective. Finally, the attribution of responsibility based on an episodic frame treatment has shown varying effects in communal vs individualistic societies (Boukes, 2022). We may, therefore, think that audience culture moderates the degree to which actions taken in a story are seen as the responsibility of the individual versus the institution.

Study 1: Police in Kenya

Case Study: DCI in Kenya

The Directorate of Criminal Investigations in Kenya (DCI) conducts all major crimes investigations for the country. It is known for being highly professionalized as compared to the general police (Interviews A, G, I as conducted by the author, details in appendix A), but is also known for corruption, disappearances, and extrajudicial violence (Interviews A, C). In a stated effort to reform their image, the department began posting true stories of their cases on Twitter in December of 2020, inspired by the communications director’s love of detective novels (Interview H). Though only 30% of the Kenyan population uses Twitter, it is a popular platform for political discussion, including tracking and reporting police malfeasance (Interviews A, G, E), and information learned through this platform likely spreads beyond the immediate users through social networks, especially as media of this form is more likely to be both repeatedly viewed and shared (Aarøe and Petersen, 2020).

The DCI authors tailor the stories, in language and content, to appeal to their audience. They relay the facts of the case, but do so while trying to make the stories as engaging as possible; one author explained that, for stories about contact between criminals and the police, they “go full throttle” (Interview H). The account exists in an environment with little entertainment media about the police and little interest or attention in most forms of government media, but phones and social media are much more accessible (Interview H).

The account has generated significant positive feedback, as well as gained 1.9 million follow-

ers. In particular it creates an appearance of transparency in a system in need of it (Interviews C, E, I, H). This transparency leads to greater trust in this institution (Interview F) and institutions generally (Warren, Sulaiman and Jaafar, 2014). The result has been a significant increase in information on social media, calls to an information hotline, and walk-ins off the street; all important for the department to operate (Interview H).³

However, this account also exists amidst a context of high distrust in law enforcement (Interviews A, H). Similar to other African countries (Omeni, 2022), the Kenyan police is still associated with its long history as a brutal, colonial system (Interviews E, F, G, H, I).⁴ Attempts at reform have been faced with both within government push-back (Interviews A, C, D, F, I) and an entrenched culture of fear and expectations of obsequence over law enforcement (Interviews A, D, E, F, I). Further, the account is contrasted by ongoing problems with violence from the DCI, complaints of lack of respect for due process (leading to cases of citizen violence against suspects named on Twitter), and central government disapproval of the tone of the account (Interviews A, C, G). Therefore, it is unclear what the overall reaction to this account is, as it is likely a population hard to influence towards trust.

Observational Data and Design

This account offers an opportunity to directly test the effects of real-world stories on an audience. I do so in two ways. First, I test whether users respond differently to narratives posted by the DCI when the case is presented as a story instead of a more straightforward format. Second, I test whether Twitter users who follow the DCI versus the National Police Service vary in how they discuss the police generally on Twitter.

³The department declined to share data on these changes, but shifts in engagement were noted by both representatives of the DCI and others who work on police reform but are unaffiliated with the department.

⁴The most revered figures in the police continue to be white, British detectives, known for being strong-men. A notable example is Patrick Shaw who began as a member of the Nairobi Special Police during colonization, was mentioned by multiple people I spoke to, and has been discussed as a somewhat mythic figure in policing (Smith, 2020).

Twitter Data

DCI Account

I scraped all tweets from the DCI account, starting with its inception in December 2020 and through October 2022⁵, condensed by thread. After removing threads with only one tweet, there was a total of 623 threads, 504 of which were about specific cases handled by the DCI and 119 of which were other updates, such as training progress and the success of the department’s volleyball team. I recorded the number of words and tweets for each thread, and aggregated responses, likes, and retweets by thread.

I marked threads about police cases by which crimes appeared, using common crime types as seed words and a bag of words model to identify potential synonyms; I used a similar process to identify cases where an arrest was made.⁶ I scored the threads about cases by how much they fit a “story” structure – following a exposition-climax-resolution order – from 0 to 1, with 1 being a “perfect story”.⁷

Lastly, classified the sentiment of the replies to the threads using an SVM classifier. Since SVM classifies based on the whole text rather than the presence of words, it is preferable for short-form text like Tweets. Each tweet was labeled by two models: one classified five emotions (anger, fear, sadness, joy, and neutral) (Albu and Spînu, 2022) and one which capture positive-negative-neutral sentiment.⁸

NPS Account

The National Police Service (NPS) also runs a Twitter account, sharing similar information as the DCI, about cases and administration, but in a much more straightforward fashion. As such, it would attract a similar audience who is viewing similar information, but in a much more

⁵Due to scraping multiple sources and wanting to keep dates mostly aligned, I put in place an original stop point of March 2022. I was in the process of adding additional data to this when Twitter (now X) began changing its rules around API usage.

⁶Crimes were: robbery, murder, drugs, assault, and rape. Coding for these crimes resulted in every thread which was about a crime having at least one crime type label. I used a GloVe word embeddings model to find a set of related words for each crime. These were hand pruned to remove related words which would reasonably appear in a non-crime context. The dictionary was applied after stemming the original text and dictionary words to account for different usages.

⁷This method was developed by the author in a separate paper. See Appendix C.

⁸The former picks up more nuance, the latter accounts for phrases like “good job” which are positive but don’t contain a specific emotion.

direct manner as compared to the stories on the DCI account. I scraped all Tweets from the NPS from December 2020 to March 2022.⁹ NPS tweets were aggregated to 799 unique threads, 148 on police cases and 651 on other topics. Each thread was labeled by case characteristics and all reaction metrics and responses to these threads were collected and classified. Though as compared to the DCI, more threads deal with administrative updates, within tweets about police cases, crime types appear with similar frequencies in each account.

Follower Timelines

To see the broader reaction to these accounts, I scraped the timelines of a randomly selected subset of the followers of each account. These were selected after filtering out accounts that were: verified, labeled as being outside Kenya, had no tweets, were active only before or after the DCI account began, and followed both the DCI and the NPS (2% of users). I ultimately scraped the timelines of 70,000 followers of the DCI and 10,000 followers of the NPS.¹⁰ I then found all tweets which mention a topic related to the police, removed re-tweets of the DCI or NPS, and classified the sentiment of each tweet.¹¹ The result was 333,555 tweets roughly evenly split between NPS and DCI followers.

Effects of Stories

First, I test the effects of telling stories about cases within the DCI account. Each thread about a case is condensed into a single vignette, along with all response to that thread. I test:

$$Sentiment_i = \beta StoryScore_i + X_i + \epsilon \quad (1)$$

The outcome is the sentiment of the responses to each thread i . The main independent variable is the *StoryScore*, a score from 0 to 1 with 1 being when a thread perfectly follows a story structure as defined. Details about this score can be found in Appendix C. Controls include whether an arrest was made in the case and the type of crime depicted. I expect β to be

⁹Twitter revoked API access before I could finish scraping tweets from October 2022.

¹⁰The NPS data collection began later and was curtailed by the revocation of the Twitter API.

¹¹A dictionary to identify tweets related to the police was developed using a bag-of-words method, specifically passing seed words to a GloVe model and hand-pruning the output.

positive – that is I expect that more “story-like” cases will generate a more positive sentiment from audiences.

Difference-in-Differences Design

Beyond any changes to sentiment from directly interacting with a story, I also test whether following the DCI account shifts opinions of the police generally using a difference-in-differences design, using tweets about the police from followers of the DCI vs the NPS before and after the DCI account becomes active.

$$Outcome_i = \beta DCIActive_i * FollowDCI_i + \gamma_u + \delta_t + \epsilon \quad (2)$$

I test two outcomes: first, the likelihood of tweeting about the police generally and DCI specifically and second, the sentiment of each tweet, scored as -1 (anger, sadness fear), 0 (neutral), or 1 (joy), with the full emotions results in Appendix D.3. γ and δ represent author and year fixed effects respectively, which absorb the non-interactive terms. As such β represents the change in each outcome for those who follow the DCI once the account becomes active.

Design Limitations

Two notes on this observational analysis are useful. First, neither analysis presented in this design is sufficient for identification, given the difficulty of directly attributing any changes in sentiment to either the account or the mechanisms outlined related to stories. I also cannot observe when followers opt into following the DCI and I would expect some unobservable difference between groups, meaning I do not necessarily expect the parallel trends assumption to hold. However, it is strongly indicative descriptively of the overall effect of the account in a real world setting, given the strict within author specification. Further, I present several experiments below to directly test the causal claims.

Second, the relevant outcome motivated in this paper is trust in the police. However, trust is extremely difficult to measure in text, particularly short text like tweets which contains a limited

number of characters. I measure sentiment as a proxy for two reasons. First, sentiment has been used in previous studies as a stand-in for trust, due to similar logistic challenges (e.g. Calderon et al., 2015), and in past surveys affect towards and trust in the police have been positively correlated and significantly predictive.¹² Second, speculatively, the mechanisms outlined related to how stories lead to trust all run through the emotions produced and the ability to generate empathy. As such, these results could be viewed as observing the intermediate step between communication and trust.

Observational Results

Sentiment in Response to Storytelling

Is telling stories on an official police account an effective means of reaching out to the public? On a basic level, the tweets that tell stories of DCI cases garner significantly more engagement than other types of information, while there is no difference in engagement by content for the NPS account (Table 7 in Appendix D.1). But is this pattern attributable to storytelling? Table 1 shows the relationship between threads that tell more of a story, as classified by the structure of the text (Appendix C), and the sentiments of replies. The full results, including controls, can be seen in Appendix Table 10.

As seen in Column 1, cases that are written as more of a story produce significantly more positive (versus negative) sentiment in replies to the DCI. While the effect size is relatively small, being a “perfect” story predicts an increase in positive sentiment significantly larger than if an arrest is made. Looking instead at the emotions displayed in columns 2-5, there is a clear increase in anger, sadness, and joy and a decrease in fear.¹³ This is descriptively in line

¹²For instance: the ANES-GSS 2020 panel includes both a feeling thermometer towards police and a question on whether police use force appropriately. These outcomes are both correlated and the feeling thermometer score significantly predicts opinions on use of force, after controlling for key aspects such as experiences with police and race. This is of course not conclusive or causal, but does indicate that affect and trust are in some way related.

¹³I include both emotions and sentiment to account for a range of expressions in text – e.g. the emotion classifier scores “good job” as neutral while a tweet which includes “waste of tax payer money” is classified as angry but neutral using a positive-negative model. Given the imperfections of sentiment scoring, as well as the difficulty to interpret pure sentiment, both models are used to provide a fuller picture.

Table 1: Sentiment of Replies to DCI Threads

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	Pos. Sentiment	Anger	Sadness	Fear	Joy
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Story Score	0.091*** (0.021)	0.035*** (0.013)	0.048*** (0.012)	-0.108*** (0.016)	0.055*** (0.011)
Constant	-0.107*** (0.015)	0.089*** (0.009)	0.056*** (0.008)	0.265*** (0.011)	0.036*** (0.008)
Observations	132,784	132,784	132,784	132,784	132,784
R ²	0.004	0.001	0.003	0.001	0.0003
Adjusted R ²	0.004	0.001	0.003	0.001	0.0002

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Controls include crime type and whether an arrest was made

with theories that suggest that stories encourage an audience to have more empathy for the protagonists and more emotional processing of events, including experiencing sadness or anger in response to crimes, and more relief or loss of fear when crimes are dealt with effectively. All of this may correlate with more appreciation for the necessity of police. Though sentiment does not perfectly represent trust, these patterns do suggest that by telling a story rather than sharing case details in another format, the DCI is able to change the sentiment of their audience, likely to the benefit of the department

Changes to Overall Police Sentiment

Table 2 shows the within author effects of the DCI account becoming active for followers of the DCI versus NPS. Columns 1 and 2 show that followers of the DCI become much more likely to discuss the police generally and the DCI specifically once the account becomes active. Note this does not include retweets of the DCI (or NPS) and so is not a mechanical result of the account being active.

Turning to the results on sentiment, while followers of the DCI use more negative sentiment while talking about the police and the NPS after the account becomes active, they are more

Table 2: Effects of Following DCI

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	Discuss Police	Discuss DCI	Sentiment		
			All Tweets	Discuss DCI	Discuss NPS (5)
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
In Period* Follow DCI	0.003*** (0.00003)	0.002*** (0.00002)	−0.003** (0.0001)	0.004* (0.0004)	−0.020*** (0.00004)
Author-Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	14,438,941	14,438,941	333,555	69,723	46,819
R ²	0.026	0.018	0.089	0.202	0.246
Adjusted R ²	0.025	0.017	0.047	0.058	0.075

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

positive about the DCI specifically relative to NPS followers. Breaking this down into specific emotions in Appendix D.3 shows this comes in large part from an increase in joy and decrease in sadness (both significant at the 5% level) in tweets that mention the DCI. This suggests that while exposure to these stories shifts perspectives positively about the agency depicted, this doesn't extend to the police as a whole and may in fact cast other police agencies in a comparatively negative light. This would descriptively fall in line with exposure to these stories being persuasive as to the quality of the DCI, but this may contrast with knowledge of the police more broadly.

Survey Experiment in Kenya

While the observational results are indicative of a positive effect on attitudes toward police from storytelling, it is difficult to establish causality or investigate mechanisms, as well as to directly observe trust. Therefore, I fielded a survey experiment¹⁴ which randomly assigned participants to one of a set of four vignettes.¹⁵ Each vignette relayed the same case in a paragraph, but rewritten to vary elements of how the case is told. The narrative was adapted

¹⁴Pre-registration plan as an appendix, IRB-FY2023-7711. The full results registered in the pre-analysis plan are discussed in Appendix E.8.

¹⁵Full text of vignettes is available in Appendix E.2.

from a DCI Twitter thread wherein two suspects were killed by police officers after stealing an officer’s weapon the day prior. The survey paused on the page with the vignette for 15 seconds to ensure participants read the vignette.

The most basic version of the vignette follows the format of many more traditional police case summaries or articles: it leads with the most important information (that two suspects were killed by police officers), then fills in the details after, and has a similarly attention grabbing headline. A second version of the incident follows what I’ve defined as a story structure: it starts with the setting and the inciting incident, follows the steps the officers took, and ends with the ultimate conclusion where two suspects were killed. The accompanying headline is vague about the conclusion of the case. This vignette could be considered a bundled treatment, in that it included somewhat different language and was slightly longer rather than simply reordering the same sentences, but the factual content did not change across versions of the vignette.

To benchmark the effects of storytelling, I included versions of the basic and story vignettes that wove in elements of procedural justice, a well known strategy to build trust in police (Nivette, Nägel and Stan, 2022; Mazerolle et al., 2013). These versions highlighted that officers asked for citizen input, followed the code of conduct, and treated people with respect. The “basic” version of the procedural justice treatment serves as grounds to logically update in favor of the police, i.e. with real reasons to expect the officers in the vignette are competent. Therefore, the contrast between the storytelling and basic procedural justice vignettes tests of the ability of a story to persuade with emotion versus rational updating. This is substantively similar to comparing the effects of manipulating views about the competence and ethics of individuals (Bannister and Connolly, 2011) with the standards of institutions (Warren, 2018) on trust outcomes.

The main outcomes of interest are two questions pertaining to the story:

- Do you think the officers in the story made the right decisions?
- Do you think they would make the right decisions in future cases?

Each of these items is measured on a 3-point scale, the options being “Yes”, “Maybe”, and “No”, as well as a “Don’t know” option excluded from analysis.¹⁶ I expect that by showing events in context, from the perspective of the officers, and allowing for narrative transportation rather than analyzing all decisions against the known outcome, the audience will be more likely to believe the officers did the right thing and to trust their judgment in future cases. Due to space constraints, I address additional pre-registered hypotheses, including experience with police as a moderator, in Appendix E.8.

In order to be commensurable with the Twitter analysis, the survey was fielded with current university students and recent graduates using a link seeded through a contact at the University of Nairobi. Though this group may be less likely to have regular interactions with police, they also are more likely to be critical of law enforcement than, for instance, low resourced populations who often want *more* police presence to deter criminals (Interview C, F). Additionally, in contrast with expectations, history with law enforcement did not moderate effects (Appendix E.1), limiting concerns about the population biasing results. Participants were told they could distribute the link to anyone qualified who may want to participate. Each participant was paid 200ksh or about \$1.50 through MPesa, a popular mobile payment app used throughout Kenya. Any duplicate respondents were filtered out using first Qualtrics’ “ballot box stuffing” feature and second based on the numbers used for payment. The survey was fielded on August 8, 2023, with 830 respondents after filtering out duplicates.

To test mediators, a second version of the survey experiment was fielded on March 19, 2024 for a total of 1,018 usable responses, using the same recruitment process as the first survey but a new respondent pool. This version used only the “basic” and “story” vignettes and after replicating the original results, asked a series of questions designed to test the four interrelated mechanisms outlined in the theory: entertainment, anxiety, perspective taking, and analytical processing. There were two additional treatments to test a fifth mechanism: that learning events in a given sequence changes how an audience processes or reacts to new information. The vignettes were broken into three pieces and respondents were asked at each stage if they

¹⁶1.1% of respondents answered “Don’t know”

agree with the actions of the police, allowing me to test how their opinions shift in response to each piece of information. The full set of questions and treatments is in Appendix E.4.

Finally, given the sensitive nature of the topic and questions, respondents were reminded several times that the study had no government affiliation and all responses would be kept anonymous, including before asking consent to participate, which was necessary to view the survey. This was reiterated before asking any personal questions about experiences with police, which participants could decline to answer without penalty. Though mobile numbers had to be collected to remit payment, respondents were informed they would be immediately deleted upon payment and not attached to their data. They were debriefed at the end about the purpose of the study and the treatment randomization and given an opportunity to withdraw consent; 14 and 24 respondents in the first and second surveys respectively opted to withdraw consent; this did not differ significantly by treatment condition, except for those in the second survey who were given step-by-step treatments.¹⁷ When offered the chance to comment, several respondents indicated the importance of maintaining anonymity, however there were no noted concerns about privacy. Though compensation was sufficient to induce participation and compensate for time, it was not high enough to coerce participation in an otherwise sensitive subject. The full study design was run by multiple context experts to ensure it was appropriate, as well as to ensure the manipulation of both structure and procedural justice was meaningful in context.

Kenyan Experimental Results

Effects of Stories

The experiment directly manipulates the structure of the same information and measures trust. Column 1 of Table 3 shows that not only does a story format significantly increase the likelihood participants thought the officers in the case made the right decisions, including killing two suspects, but the effect size is almost double that of including elements of procedural justice. Reading a story makes participants 0.8 standard deviations more likely to believe

¹⁷16 people in these conditions withdrew as opposed to 8 in the block vignette conditions. Given the small number who chose to withdraw, I do not draw any significant conclusions from this.

police are making the right decision as compared to the basic version. This effect is equivalent to a Cohen’s $d = 0.83$; a large effect compared to similar procedural justice designs in past experiments (Nivette, Nägel and Stan, 2022). Considering the success of procedural justice as a builder of trust in both vignette studies and applied training programs, it is a good benchmark for the relative effect of storytelling. The interactive effect of both elements does not show a significant improvement, perhaps speaking to a relative ceiling on how much people can update.

Table 3: Effect of Vignettes

	Right Decision	Future Decisions
	(1)	(2)
Procedural Justice	0.382*** (0.085)	0.250*** (0.078)
Story	0.659*** (0.088)	0.254*** (0.080)
Justice+Story	0.581*** (0.086)	0.283*** (0.079)
Constant	0.042 (0.060)	0.259*** (0.055)
Observations	629	626
R ²	0.100	0.027
Adjusted R ²	0.096	0.022
<i>Note:</i>	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01	

Turning to column (2), the question of whether officers will make the right decision in the future, we see that both storytelling and procedural justice, as well as their interaction, produce roughly equivalent increases in trust versus a ‘basic’ vignette that had neither element. Again, storytelling has a persuasive effect competitive with procedural justice. Together these outcomes represent what we might think of as the relevant dimension of trust in this context: that the police have both the competence and future incentive to not betray citizens. It is notable that this result can be achieved without changing the information imparted, rather by

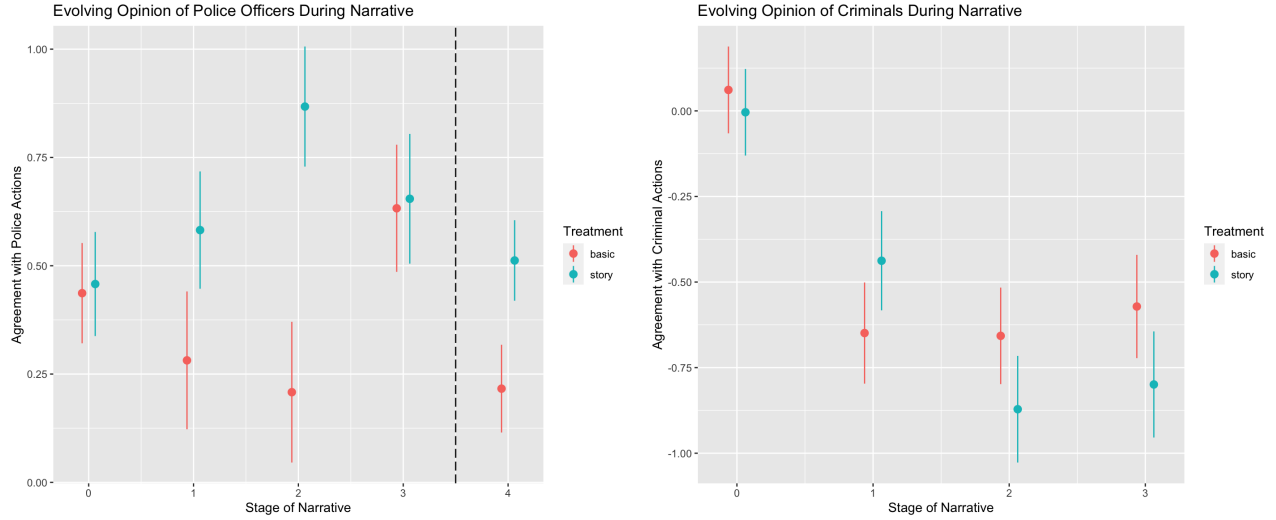


Figure 1: Updating of Opinions During Vignettes

changing how this information is shared. The second round experiment included only the basic and story treatments, so is not included in this table, but replicates similar effects. Both these round two results and an alternate representation of the results in Table 3 can be found in Appendix E.3.

Mechanisms Underlying the Story Effect

Where does this effect come from? I conduct a full mediation analysis in Appendix E.5, which shows that worry for the fate of the police, understanding the police officers decisions and why events played out the way they did, and being less skeptical of officers version of events mediate the effect of storytelling on trust. Entertainment or engrossment showed only weak mediation effects. However, these factors only account for a portion of the persuasive effect of the story; there remains a considerable direct effect that could not be accounted for by the measurements used, which merits further study.

In addition to post-treatment questions, I also fielded a version of the vignettes wherein participants were asked the degree to which they approved of the police and the criminals actions at multiple points in the narrative. As seen in Figure 1, while the two groups have consistently similar opinions of the criminal suspects, when asked about their opinions of the police, those in the story condition always have a more positive opinion than they did at

baseline, while those in the basic condition update negatively for the first two segments of the vignette. They have a bump in approval in response to the final piece of information (that the suspects shot first), but as seen in $t = 4$, in the end those in the story condition are still more likely to say they think the officers made the right decisions. I attribute this to the fact that those in the story condition are consistently more positive about police actions, while those in the basic condition update significantly negatively at first. The final outcome could be seen as a sum of the opinions held across the narrative, wherein more positive versus negative feelings were produced overall in the story condition as compared to the basic one, supporting the idea that the context within which audiences learn information matters even when the actual information is the same.

Study 2: the DMV and Fire Department in the U.S.

Although the DCI provides a useful example of a real world campaign using storytelling, many questions remain about the generalizability of the findings. To bolster the claim that this mode of communication is generally effective at generating support for and trust in government agencies, I repeat this experiment in the United States using new government institutions. The second case shows that the effectiveness of government storytelling, manipulating only the structure of information and not the information itself, applies beyond the context of the DCI.

The scope of this study focuses on government communications in democracies, where there are incentives to communicate relatively accurate information about government but also a need for public trust and approval for which storytelling might serve a purpose. The U.S. is a substantively important case given these parameters to understand the potential impacts of government communication. Further, though sharing some similarities with Kenya, citizens in the U.S. have on average different expectations of government, more emphasis on individual level responsibility, and a different information environment, providing useful contrast as to where storytelling may be effective.

Institution Selection and Vignette Design

Though there are many examples and instances of government storytelling (Gooch, 2018), there are rarely scrapable sources such as the DCI Twitter account that shared hundreds of official stories for public consumption. Instead, to replicate building the survey design from real government representatives’ communication and bolster the external validity of the experiment, I drew from officials who shared stories of their experiences on a public forum (Reddit).¹⁸

I selected two of these narratives to adapt into treatment vignettes based on several criteria. First, I chose institutions the general public would be familiar with, one low stakes and one high stakes institution. Second, within accounts of those institutions, I chose incidents in which a critical decision was made by a government representative that led to a controversial outcome. As in the story about the Kenyan police, in which someone was killed by an officer, I wanted to test the effectiveness of storytelling such that whether the government official made the “right” decision could go either way. I ultimately adapted an incident at a DMV (a relatively disliked, low stakes institution) where someone was denied from being allowed to register their vehicle and an incident from a fire department (a relatively liked, high stakes institution) where a delay in firefighting due to a firefighter entering a building unauthorized in order to save someone led to structural damage. As in the previous experiment, for each incident I wrote two vignettes that contained the same information and largely the same word choices. However, one was written such that the most important information came first and details filled in after, while the other was written as a story. The full text of the vignettes is in Appendix F.

Experiment Procedure

The survey was fielded on January 12, 2026 on a representative sample through Cint Theorem.¹⁹ Participants were then asked about their baseline trust in a set of government institutions, including the DMV and Fire Department. Treatments were grouped into two blocks,

¹⁸I used the `r/IAmA` and `r/AMA` subreddits, where anyone who wants to host a thread answers questions put to them by the public. Scraping these pages showed hundreds of politicians and bureaucrats who have participated in similar discussions, many of which included stories about their experiences.

¹⁹IRB-2025-1135

one for each institution. Each block included a randomly selected vignette, either the basic version or a story, and questions about whether the government official in the story made the right decision and would continue to make the right decisions in the future. I also asked if participants believed the official had good intentions, was telling the truth about events, and was representative of the institution as a whole, as well as an attention check related to some detail of the vignette. The order of the two blocks was also randomized and treatment was randomized by block rather than participant, meaning a participant could see the DMV basic treatment followed by the Fire Department story treatment, or both story treatments starting with Fire and then DMV, or any other combination thereof. Finally participants were debriefed as to the purpose of the experiment and given an opportunity to withdraw their consent.

A total of 2,031 responses were collected. After filtering for those who gave consent at the beginning and end of the survey (127 participants removed) and who passed both attention checks,²⁰ there were 879 observations. There was no differential removal by treatment condition. Results do not substantively change if the full sample is included.

Results

As shown in Table 4, the effect of telling a story as opposed to presenting the same information in a “basic” format increases the likelihood that participants say public officials did make and will make the right decisions. For both the DMV and the Fire Department vignettes, reading a story made participants significantly more likely to say that the respective representatives of those departments made the right decision in the circumstances described (an effect equivalent to 0.37 and 0.45 standard deviations respectively). The DMV story was much less interesting and much lower stakes in terms of both decision making and outcomes as compared to the fire department story, but in both cases, the way in which audiences learned about information significantly changed their evaluation of events.

In contrast, only the DMV story moved opinions about whether representatives would make

²⁰Respondents were given multiple options for some detail of the story, e.g. how the fire started, only those who answered correctly were included.

Table 4: Institutional Storytelling in the U.S.

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	DMV		Fire	
	Right Decision (1)	Future Decision (2)	Right Decision (3)	Future Decision (4)
Story	0.298*** (0.056)	0.219*** (0.045)	0.347*** (0.052)	0.051 (0.034)
Constant	1.958*** (0.041)	2.245*** (0.033)	2.191*** (0.037)	2.693*** (0.024)
Observations	865	865	865	864
R ²	0.032	0.027	0.050	0.003
Adjusted R ²	0.031	0.026	0.049	0.001

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

the right decisions in the future. The coefficient for the Fire Department vignettes is in the expected direction but not significant. There are two potential interpretations of this. First, given that the story depicted a member of the Fire Department making a high stakes decision that went against policy, audiences might believe it was acceptable in this case but be unsure about their decision making overall. However, the results from the Case 1 experiment in Kenya showed that a story persuaded audiences to trust police to the same or greater degree as manipulating perceptions of procedural justice, suggesting that being in accordance with policy may not be the mechanism behind levels of trust. The alternate explanation would be ceiling effects; the control group already had a mean of 2.7 on a 3 point scale, so it may simply be difficult to move opinion in a significantly positive direction from there.²¹

In sum, these results support the conclusions in Case 1: telling a story as opposed to other forms of conveying the same information increases trust in government representatives, despite their taking controversial actions. Further, it does not appear that disliking an institution or the relative interest level of the story significantly curtail these effects. However, it may be

²¹Only 11 people disagreed that the firefighter would make the right decision in the future in the basic treatment condition.

more difficult to increase trust in well liked institutions simply because trust in them is already relatively high.

Trust in Institutions

To expand on these results, that telling a story significantly increases institutional trust, I asked three more questions: do you believe the public official depicted told the truth about how events unfolded, did they have good intentions, and are they representative of the institution as a whole? The first outcome, columns 1 and 4 in Table 5, replicates the effect found in Case 1: telling a story significantly increases the likelihood audiences believe public officials are telling the truth about events. This is a substantively important result as we think about government accountability; public officials often have reason to want the public to believe a version of events that paints their decisions in an acceptable light.

Table 5: Storytelling and Beliefs in the U.S.

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	DMV			Fire		
	Truth (1)	Intentions (2)	Representative (3)	Truth (4)	Intentions (5)	Representative (6)
Story	0.299*** (0.045)	0.313*** (0.051)	0.033 (0.056)	0.102*** (0.034)	0.031 (0.019)	0.212*** (0.056)
Constant	2.257*** (0.033)	2.191*** (0.037)	1.891*** (0.041)	2.684*** (0.024)	2.914*** (0.014)	2.063*** (0.039)
Observations	864	865	864	864	864	863
R ²	0.049	0.042	0.0004	0.011	0.003	0.017
Adjusted R ²	0.048	0.041	−0.001	0.009	0.002	0.015

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

The remaining two outcomes have positive but not always statistically significant effects. When asked about the intentions of officials, there is a positive and significant effect for the DMV story but not for the Fire Department. Again, however, the control group constant for the Fire Department vignettes is 2.9 on a 3 point scale, suggesting ceiling effects. Therefore, I think

it is reasonable to conclude that telling a story causes audiences to be less cynical about public officials' intentions, even if their decisions have a poor outcome. Last, audiences were only significantly more likely to say the depicted firefighter was representative of the institution as a whole. As there is extensive work documenting how negative interactions with representatives of an institution color overall perceptions of that institution (e.g. Lawless and Fox, 2001), I theorize that participants' direct interactions with a DMV made them less willing to update their overall opinion. However, given that repeated messaging from the DCI was associated with an increase in positive sentiment, it is possible that being repeatedly exposed to positive stories further change overall opinions of an institution, over and above any single story.

Discussion

Storytelling can be effective at building trust in government representatives and their associated institutions, even when those representatives have taken controversial actions. Though there is extensive work on storytelling and framing, previous studies have manipulated both content and structure; the effect identified here holds content constant and shows structure alone can induce an effect. Further, past work has demonstrated that stories can be an effective form of persuasion, but in reference to individual behaviors or attitudes towards out-groups post conflict, rather than a government institution. Looking at a mix of institutions, country contexts, and levels of public trust, I show that storytelling as opposed to presenting the same information in a more standard (ending first) format is effective at inducing greater trust in an audience, including more belief in the government account of events. This is due to a mix of mechanisms, including that information is viewed differently depending on the context within which it is learned. In addition to increasing trust and belief in public officials' benevolence, I have also shown suggestive evidence that stories, especially upon repeat exposure, lead citizens to update their opinion about institutions as a whole. This ability to manipulate trust simply through the structure of information has not been identified in previous studies of political communication or storytelling.

These findings have potentially concerning implications for government accountability. First, there are many circumstances in which in democracies governments have incentives to elicit sympathetic interpretations of events from citizens. The fact that this was achievable through a relatively minor (and cheap) change to information structure is concerning when we think about what citizens learn about potentially problematic government actions. As stories are more entertaining, they may also spread more easily beyond the immediate audience.²² Further, as compared to most other examples of propaganda, it may be harder to counter any effects of a technically truthful story on public opinion. Though this study focuses on stories about governments by governments, similar mechanisms and outcomes are likely at work in broader media about government institutions such as police procedurals or sitcoms about the DMV. These may be even more effective at building trust, given that audiences are likely less skeptical of the source.

Second, as we have seen in Kenya, stories on social media have induced a population to be more willing to directly interact and share information with the police both anecdotally (Interview H) and according to the survey data (see Table 22 in Appendix E.7). Information sharing is necessary for the functioning of the institution, but also carries its own associated risks.

However, the effects of storytelling about a government agency exist within a larger world. When citizens directly interact with agencies that they have heard stories about, negative interactions may lead to even more disappointment or lower trust than in a world where they had never read a story about the institution. Discussions about the DCI indicated that citizens were encouraged to ask for help after reading about police’s successes through the Twitter account but were ultimately even more disillusioned upon being disappointed by their real life interactions (Interviews D, F, H). When reading responses to DMV workers online, a significant portion of responses included anecdotes along the lines of “I think good employees like you are in the minority, I had a bad experience at...”. This suggests that in order to have trust effects that last and reach the broader population, institutional reform may also be necessary in the

²²Though there is little Kenyan media on the police, children are exposed to Paw Patrol.

long-term.

A question might remain: if this is so effective, why do other agencies not participate? When discussing the DCI account with stakeholders in government transparency, they mentioned both that other institutions have less of a need for public information (including non-investigative branches of the police), and therefore less incentive to reach out (Interview I). Additionally, some government officials view storytelling as unprofessional (Interviews A, C, G). However, both work in the U.S. (Gooch, 2018) and my own review of public communication have shown storytelling is often used anecdotally, but not perhaps systematically. This may be in part because this is a relatively understudied communication mechanism.

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Appendix

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A Interview Coding

Interviews are labeled by a brief description of the person / organization and the date. All interviews took place in person in Nairobi. Individuals and organizations were contacted directly by the author and fully informed of the authors' institutional affiliation and the purpose of the study prior to agreeing to participate, and again at the outset of the interview. Every individual interviewed was a reporter, a member of the Kenyan government, or a member of an institution in the Police Reform Working Group, which was appointed to oversee and make recommendations on national police reform, minimizing concerns about power imbalances. There was no undue influence and the only incentive offered to participate was the purchase of a cup of coffee or tea during the interview. Since the purpose of the interviews was to learn about the history and current status of police reform and the impact of the account being studied no deception was necessary and it did not constitute interference in ongoing political processes. As such, participants were only asked about topics within the purview of their daily work, and did not therefore induce undue harm. I requested permission to make notes and asked participants whether they were willing to be identified or quoted directly. Several requested not to be explicitly identified, but all consented to be cited in reference to their professional role. The only details included from interviews which could identify a specific individual were those directly from the author of the account; he has provided similar information previously in published newspaper articles and consented to the inclusion in this work.

- A. Member of police reform group, part of PRWG, July 1, 2023.
- B. Journalist, July 4, 2023.
- C. Community legal representative, part of PRWG, July 5, 2023.
- D. Government oversight official, July 7, 2023.
- E. Journalist, July 7, 2023.
- F. Two members of a constitution reform institute, part of PRWG, July 10, 2023.

G. Government oversight official, July 11, 2023.

H. Representative of the DCI, July 12, 2023.

I. Member of human rights research center, July 14, 2023.

B Example Stories

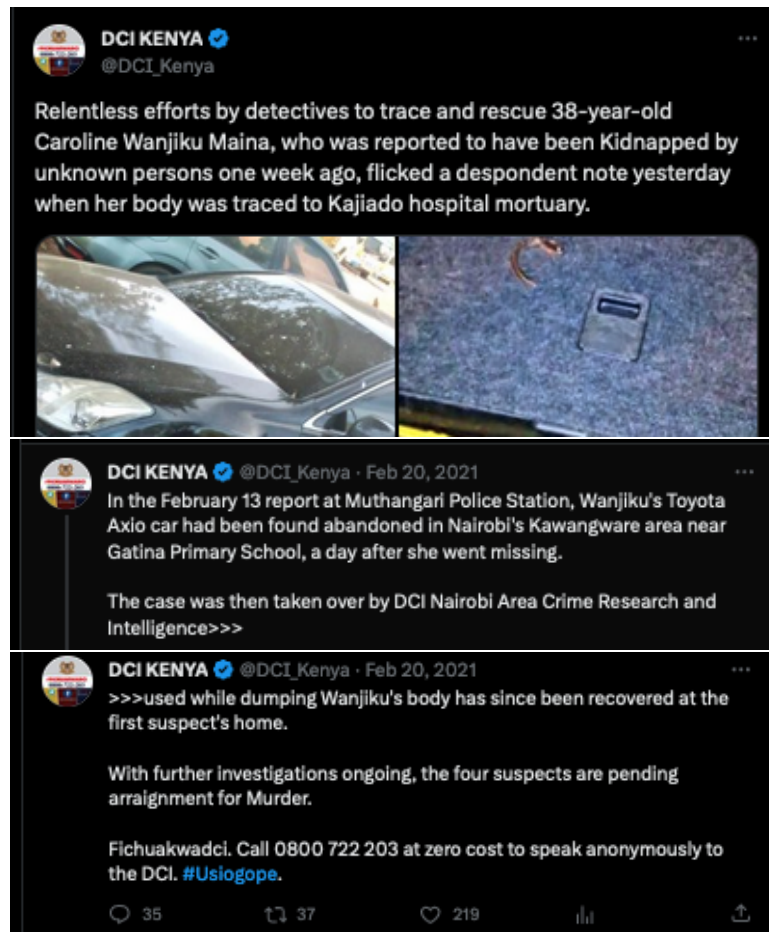


Figure 2: Example DCI Story

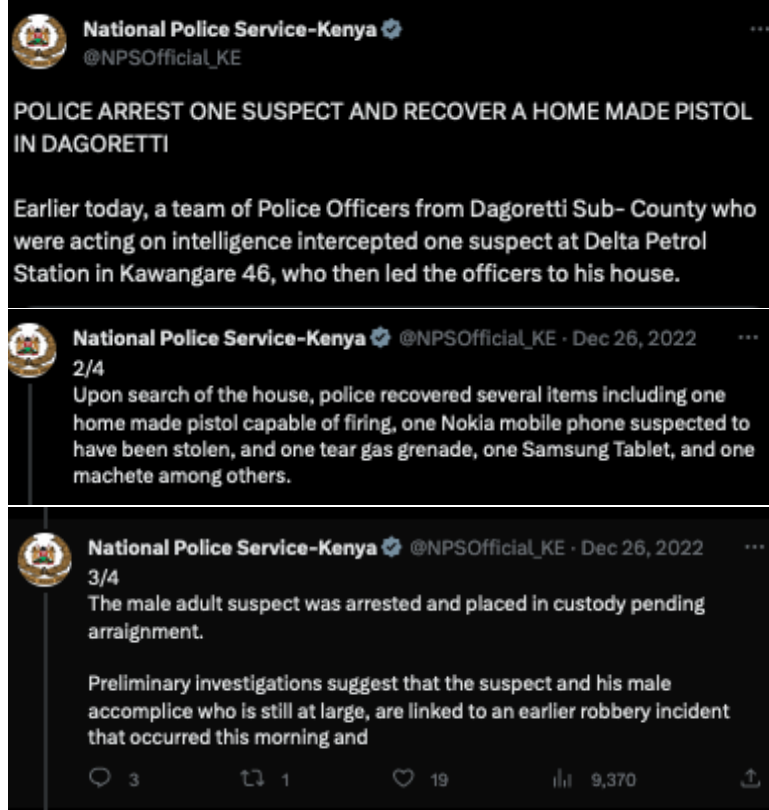


Figure 3: Example NPS Story

C Story Scoring Method

Each thread about a case from the DCI account is scored by the degree to which it fits a “story” structure, defined in this paper as following an exposition-rising action-climax-falling action-resolution format. At the outset of this paper, I discovered there were no existing approaches to either evaluate this directly or systematically assess the structure of text more broadly. Existing text methods related to narratives included: distinguishing narratives, defined as vignettes that include events and characters, from non narratives, (Antoniak et al., 2023) identifying existing narrative archetypes in text (Reagan et al., 2016), or when specific words appear (Kitagawa and Shen-Bayh, 2023). However, no existing methods were suitable for considering, given a set of characters, events, and writing style, what made one narrative more or less of a story.

Therefore, in a paper currently under review, I have developed my own text method to assess the degree to which short-form text is telling a story as defined. The basic steps are as

follows:

1. Decompose text into clauses, since sentences can contain multiple events
2. (*Optional*) Remove proper nouns and replace unusual words with common synonyms
3. Either:
 - a. Handlabel a set of clauses as to the part of a story they represent: exposition, climax, and resolution (tested labeling 300 clauses, used in this paper)
 - b. Group a smaller set of clauses (500) by their semantic similarity and label the groups (a small set allows for better clustering / labeling)
4. Use the labels to train a BERT model and label all the clauses in the dataset
5. Calculate a story score by how many swaps it would take to put the clauses in the “correct” order, as in exposition first then climax then resolution. This count is scaled by 1. the proportion of categories that appear in the document and 2. the total length of the document

Table 6: Mean Model Score as Predicts Validation Sets

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>	
	Handscore	Crowd Prop.
	(1)	(2)
Mean Score	4.423** (1.685)	1.186* (0.628)
Constant	−0.321 (1.249)	−0.387 (0.471)
Observations	34	19
R ²	0.177	0.173
Adjusted R ²	0.152	0.125
<i>Note:</i>	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01	

Given a specific seed, BERT model coding can be exactly replicated. However, there is some inherent variability in the process given different seeds. To account for this I built in two additional steps. First, each run an optimal seed is chosen out of a potential 25 which maximizes coding accuracy. Second, the score actually used in this paper for the results in table 1 is the mean of 100 runs of this whole process. If I were to bootstrap this process to

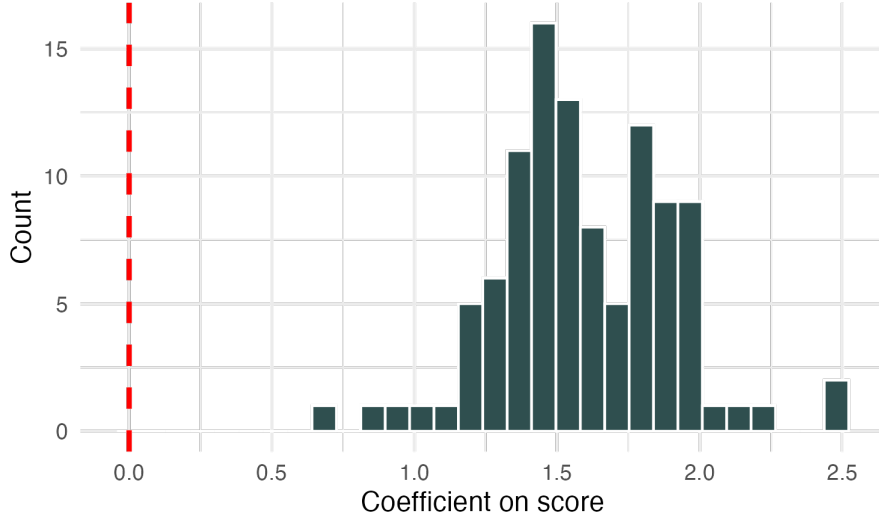


Figure 4: Distribution of Scoring Runs Predicting Known Document Type

find the mean of 10 runs, 1,000 times all but two of the resulting coefficients are greater than 0. Therefore, the results presented in this paper are not dependent on model variation but are a consistent result of evaluating text in the manner described.

The method as used in this paper has been validated in four ways. First, by ensuring the labels generated in steps 3b. and 4 are accurate with respect to the handcoded labels. I achieved above 0.6 accuracy through this method, which outperforms most sentiment classification tasks as a benchmark, and a naive GPT model labeling. Second, by comparing the final score calculated to a set of hand-scored documents. As seen in Column 1 of Table 6, the method score as used in this paper predicts the hand coded score consistently with a p-value less than 0.01. Third, I showed pairs of vignettes to crowd-workers and asked them to select which was the most “story-like”. I then used these preferences to calculate a proportion of times each of 20 narratives was selected. As seen in Column 2 of Table 6, the method created score significantly predicts this crowd preference for what constitutes a story. Finally, I scored two sets of documents of known type – news articles about crime and short fiction about crime – and found the model score for the latter group was significantly higher than for the former across 100 scoring runs. The distribution of single runs predicting this difference in means is shown in Figure 4.

For the threads scored and used in this paper, the minimum score was 0.383, the maximum score was 0.877 and the standard deviation was 0.072.

D Observational Data - Additional Results

D.1 Engagement with Accounts

As described, while the NPS and the DCI accounts cover similar topics, the structure and style of those threads varies significantly across accounts (examples in Appendix B). While we might reasonably expect that people will be more engaged with communication around crimes over administrative updates, I also expect this difference in engagement to be much more stark within the DCI account, which tells stories about their cases rather than relates facts. As a simple test of this, I use the following equation:

$$Engagement_i = \beta_1 DCIThread_i + \beta_2 AboutCrime_i + \beta_3 DCIThread_i * AboutCrime_i + X_i + \epsilon \quad (3)$$

I interact the account (NPS or DCI) with the type of post, either about a police case or about other administrative information, controlling for the total number of tweets and words. I test how this predicts retweets, replies, and likes to the respective threads on Twitter.

Table 7 shows: the DCI garners more engagement on general posts than the NPS, and an order of magnitude more for their threads about police cases specifically. By contrast, there is no significant difference for NPS threads about cases versus non-cases.

To verify these results are not driven by outliers, I include two alternate versions of the outcome: one log transformed, in Table 8, and one where each outcome has been rescaled within account, in Table 9. That is, each is scaled from 0 to 1 relative to the maximum (for instance) number of likes on all DCI stories, while the NPS outcomes are scaled by the maximum number of likes for NPS stories. The central conclusion, that DCI threads about police cases garner more engagement while there is no difference by topic for the NPS, is unchanged by these transformations.

Table 7: Engagement with DCI and NPS Threads

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Retweets	Replies	Likes
	(1)	(2)	(3)
About Crime	−5.380 (16.581)	7.655 (10.665)	−41.075 (66.209)
From DCI	86.232*** (29.420)	55.319*** (18.923)	588.666*** (117.475)
DCI*Crime	58.613*** (13.298)	37.289*** (8.553)	136.206** (53.099)
Tweet Count	−0.856*** (0.295)	−0.681*** (0.190)	−0.748 (1.178)
Word Count	115.748*** (32.352)	70.497*** (20.809)	503.241*** (129.184)
Constant	−34.722** (13.471)	−6.104 (8.665)	−154.028*** (53.791)
Observations	1,422	1,422	1,422
R ²	0.235	0.173	0.345
Adjusted R ²	0.232	0.171	0.343

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 8: Engagement with DCI and NPS Threads - Log Transformed Outcomes

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Retweets	Replies	Likes
	(1)	(2)	(3)
About Crime	0.113* (0.064)	0.456*** (0.073)	0.399*** (0.090)
From DCI	1.782*** (0.114)	1.886*** (0.129)	2.708*** (0.161)
DCI*Crime	0.201*** (0.052)	0.244*** (0.058)	0.183** (0.073)
Tweet Count	-0.003** (0.001)	-0.003** (0.001)	-0.00001 (0.002)
Word Count	0.558*** (0.126)	0.257* (0.142)	0.059 (0.176)
Constant	2.307*** (0.052)	1.309*** (0.059)	2.589*** (0.073)
Observations	1,422	1,422	1,422
R ²	0.615	0.618	0.643
Adjusted R ²	0.614	0.617	0.642
<i>Note:</i> *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01			

Table 9: Engagement with DCI and NPS Threads - Scaled Outcomes

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Retweets	Replies	Likes
	(1)	(2)	(3)
About Crime	0.006 (0.006)	0.003 (0.005)	0.002 (0.005)
From DCI	-0.005 (0.011)	0.027*** (0.009)	0.019** (0.009)
DCI*Crime	0.017*** (0.005)	0.017*** (0.004)	0.012*** (0.004)
Tweet Count	-0.0003*** (0.0001)	-0.0003*** (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)
Word Count	0.022* (0.012)	0.033*** (0.009)	0.029*** (0.010)
Constant	0.018*** (0.005)	-0.004 (0.004)	0.002 (0.004)
Observations	1,422	1,422	1,422
R ²	0.060	0.185	0.222
Adjusted R ²	0.056	0.182	0.219
<i>Note:</i> *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01			

D.2 Full Results Table 1

Table 10: Sentiment of Replies to DCI Threads

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	Sentiment	Anger	Sadness	Fear	Joy
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Story Score	0.091*** (0.021)	0.035*** (0.013)	0.048*** (0.012)	−0.108*** (0.016)	0.055*** (0.011)
Arrest Made	0.013*** (0.003)	0.004* (0.002)	−0.004** (0.002)	0.007*** (0.002)	0.004** (0.002)
Robbery	0.033*** (0.005)	−0.014*** (0.003)	−0.011*** (0.002)	0.009*** (0.003)	−0.001 (0.002)
Murder	−0.061*** (0.003)	0.010*** (0.002)	0.027*** (0.002)	0.007*** (0.002)	−0.003** (0.002)
Drug Crime	0.024*** (0.004)	−0.014*** (0.002)	0.0001 (0.002)	−0.011*** (0.003)	0.004** (0.002)
Assault	0.004 (0.003)	−0.001 (0.002)	−0.002 (0.002)	0.003 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)
Rape	−0.004 (0.005)	0.009*** (0.003)	−0.006** (0.003)	0.020*** (0.004)	0.001 (0.003)
Constant	−0.107*** (0.015)	0.089*** (0.009)	0.056*** (0.008)	0.265*** (0.011)	0.036*** (0.008)
Observations	132,784	132,784	132,784	132,784	132,784
R ²	0.004	0.001	0.003	0.001	0.0003
Adjusted R ²	0.004	0.001	0.003	0.001	0.0002

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Controls include crime type and whether an arrest was made

D.3 Full Follower Timeline Sentiment

Table 11: Sentiment of Tweets that Mention Police

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	Avg. Sentiment	Anger	Sadness	Fear	Joy
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
In Period*Treatment	−0.003** (0.0001)	−0.004** (0.0002)	0.0005 (0.0002)	0.006** (0.0002)	−0.001** (0.00002)
Author-Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	333,555	333,555	333,555	333,555	333,555
R ²	0.089	0.066	0.062	0.066	0.077
Adjusted R ²	0.047	0.024	0.019	0.024	0.035

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 12: Sentiment of Tweets that Mention the DCI

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	Avg. Sentiment	Anger	Sadness	Fear	Joy
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
In Period:Treatment	0.004* (0.0004)	−0.004* (0.0003)	−0.006** (0.0003)	0.009** (0.0003)	0.003** (0.0001)
Author-Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	69,723	69,723	69,723	69,723	69,723
R ²	0.202	0.171	0.172	0.185	0.212
Adjusted R ²	0.058	0.021	0.023	0.039	0.070

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 13: Sentiment of Tweets that Mention the NPS

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	Avg. Sentiment	Anger	Sadness	Fear	Joy
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
In Period*Treatment	-0.020*** (0.00004)	-0.006*** (0.0001)	0.008*** (0.00002)	0.009*** (0.0001)	-0.009*** (0.0001)
Author-Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	46,819	46,819	46,819	46,819	46,819
R ²	0.246	0.216	0.207	0.228	0.259
Adjusted R ²	0.075	0.039	0.027	0.053	0.091

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

E Kenya Experiment - Additional Materials

E.1 Contact with Police as a Moderator

Table 14: Being Stopped by Police as a Moderator

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	Round 1		Round 2	
	Right Decision (1)	Future Decisions (2)	Right Decision (3)	Future Decisions (4)
Procedural Justice	0.402*** (0.116)	0.162 (0.106)		
Story	0.601*** (0.120)	0.086 (0.109)	0.437*** (0.090)	0.367*** (0.078)
Justice+Story	0.469*** (0.117)	0.242** (0.107)		
Stopped by Police	−0.070 (0.121)	−0.121 (0.111)	0.119 (0.104)	0.074 (0.091)
Stopped*Justice	−0.056 (0.173)	0.175 (0.158)		
Stopped*Story	0.100 (0.177)	0.365** (0.162)	−0.014 (0.148)	−0.092 (0.130)
Stopped*J+S	0.248 (0.176)	0.050 (0.162)		
Constant	0.082 (0.084)	0.321*** (0.077)	0.018 (0.063)	0.213*** (0.055)
Observations	615	611	508	509
R ²	0.103	0.034	0.072	0.055
Adjusted R ²	0.093	0.023	0.066	0.049

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 15: Being a Victim of a Crime as a Moderator

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	Right Decision	Future Decisions	Right Decision	Future Decisions
	Round 1		Round 2	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Procedural Justice	0.446*** (0.100)	0.305*** (0.092)		
Story	0.686*** (0.104)	0.248*** (0.095)	0.449*** (0.080)	0.368*** (0.070)
Justice+Story	0.591*** (0.101)	0.281*** (0.093)		
Experienced Crime	0.162 (0.136)	0.067 (0.125)	0.102 (0.123)	0.100 (0.108)
Crime*Justice	-0.157 (0.196)	-0.151 (0.179)		
Crime*Story	-0.027 (0.199)	0.072 (0.181)	-0.134 (0.177)	-0.154 (0.155)
Crime*J+S	0.130 (0.202)	0.151 (0.187)		
Constant	-0.025 (0.071)	0.228*** (0.066)	0.044 (0.056)	0.215*** (0.049)
Observations	613	611	509	509
R ²	0.117	0.037	0.065	0.056
Adjusted R ²	0.106	0.026	0.060	0.051

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 16: Follow the DCI on Twitter as a Moderator

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>			
	Right Decision	Future Decisions	Right Decision	Future Decisions
	Round 1		Round 2	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Procedural Justice	0.477*** (0.134)	0.230* (0.125)		
Story	0.646*** (0.140)	0.067 (0.129)	0.316*** (0.106)	0.421*** (0.093)
Justice+Story	0.620*** (0.141)	0.228* (0.130)		
Follows DCI	0.143 (0.124)	0.010 (0.115)	0.079 (0.102)	0.278*** (0.089)
DCI*Justice	-0.163 (0.176)	0.0004 (0.162)		
DCI*Story	0.028 (0.182)	0.324* (0.167)	0.191 (0.144)	-0.124 (0.127)
DCI*J+S	-0.015 (0.180)	0.089 (0.166)		
Constant	-0.046 (0.095)	0.254*** (0.088)	0.035 (0.075)	0.079 (0.065)
Observations	599	596	487	486
R ²	0.113	0.040	0.080	0.085
Adjusted R ²	0.103	0.028	0.074	0.079

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

E.2 Full Text of Vignettes

Basic Vignette

Two men killed by police following firearm theft

Police officers killed two men in a standoff recently. One of the men, a known criminal,

stole a police firearm the evening before and was shot shortly after the police discovered them based on tips from citizens. The second culprit attempted to run away, but police chased him and killed him shortly after. The confrontation was the result of an extensive search after the firearm was stolen while officers conducted crowd control at the Bee Centre. Two firearms were ultimately recovered, though not before the criminals had used them against the police when the standoff began.

Story Vignette

A Summer Standoff Over Firearm Theft Leads to a Dramatic End

Officers were dispatched to deal with an unruly crowd at the Bee Centre on a recent evening. In the midst of attempting to restore order in a chaotic scene, one officer discovered his firearm had been stolen and was in the hands of an unknown person. An investigation ensued and the police discovered the weapon was in the hands of a known criminal. Concerned citizens were able to provide information to the officers tasked with finding him, and the next day several members of police found the culprit along with an accomplice who possessed an additional firearm. Rather than surrender, the two men began to fire at the police officers; the police officers returned fire and fatally wounded one of the men. The second suspect tried to flee with both weapons, but officers gave chase and the second suspect was ultimately killed as well.

Basic + Procedural Justice

Two men killed by police following firearm theft

Police officers killed two men in a standoff recently. One of the men, a known criminal, stole a police firearm the evening before. When officers found him, along with an accomplice, they warned both men they would be forced to take action unless they surrendered. However, when the suspects began shooting, police fatally wounded both. The police claim these actions were in line with the rules and laws of their department. The officers involved credit citizen engagement with providing the necessary information.

Story + Procedural Justice

A Summer Standoff Over Firearm Theft Leads to a Dramatic End

Officers were dispatched to deal with an unruly crowd at the Bee Centre on a recent evening.

In the midst of attempting to restore order in a chaotic scene, one officer discovered his firearm had been stolen and was in the hands of an unknown person. An investigation ensued and the police discovered the weapon was in the hands of a known criminal. Police engaged with concerned citizens who were able to provide information on the whereabouts of the suspect. The next day several members of police found the culprit along with an accomplice who possessed an additional firearm. Officers offered both men a chance to surrender, however instead they opened fire. The police, following the rules and laws of their department, returned fire and fatally wounded one of the men. The second suspect tried to flee with both weapons, but officers gave chase and the second suspect was ultimately killed as well.

E.3 Main Results - Alternate Specifications

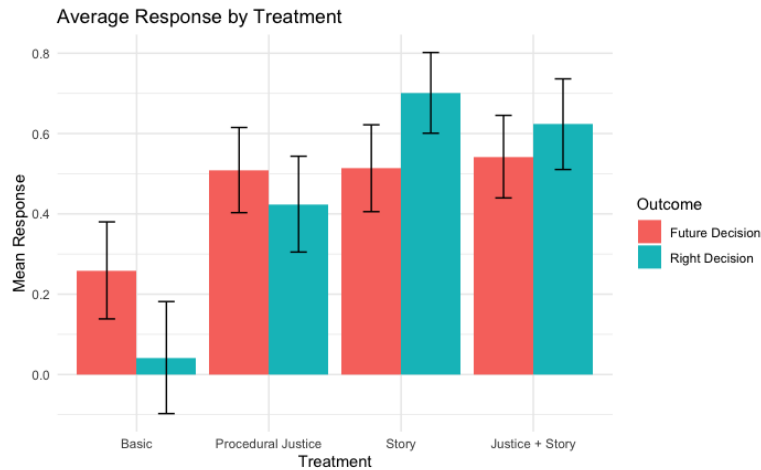


Figure 5: Table 3 as a Figure

Table 17: Vignette Effects for Second Round Survey

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>	
	Right Decision	Future Decisions
	(1)	(2)
Story	0.427*** (0.071)	0.345*** (0.062)
Constant	0.061 (0.050)	0.230*** (0.044)
Observations	514	515
R ²	0.066	0.057
Adjusted R ²	0.064	0.055
<i>Note:</i>	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01	

E.4 Mechanism Questions

Below is the full text of the questions used to test each of the five mechanisms discussed. Mediation analysis is in Appendix E.5. The last section details how the vignettes were broken into pieces and questions interspersed with regards to how the audience viewed the actors throughout. The labels correspond to the time periods shown in Figure 1.

Entertainment

1. How willing would you be to read another similar narrative? (Not at all, Neutral, Very willing)
[*How much do you agree with the following (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):*]
2. I read the narrative but I was thinking about other things.
3. I had to try to stay focused.
4. I was annoyed the “next page” button was delayed

Anxiety

[How much do you agree with the following (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):]

5. I was worried about the fate of the officers while I was reading the narrative.
6. I was worried about the fate of the criminals while I was reading the narrative.
7. I felt tense or wound up while reading the narrative.

Perspective

[How much do you agree with the following (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):]

8. I could easily imagine myself making similar decisions as the officers in the story.
9. I could easily imagine myself making similar decisions as the alleged criminals in the story.
10. I understood why events unfolded the way they did.

Judgment

11. Would you want to ask the officers in the story any questions about their decisions? (Yes, No, Don't know)
12. The officers in this story then reported that the criminals fired the first shots. Which of the following comes closest to your view? (That seems very plausible given what I read in the account, That seems somewhat plausible given what I read in the account, That seems somewhat implausible given what I read in the account, That seems very implausible given what I read in the account)

Updating of Information

Basic Version with Questions

[$T = 0$] You're about to read about an incident involving several police officers and alleged criminals. Before reading, how much do you think you'll agree with the actions of:

(Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree)

- The police

- The alleged criminals

[$T = 1$] Police officers killed two men in a standoff recently. One of the men, a known criminal, stole a police firearm the evening before and was shot shortly after the police discovered them based on tips from citizens.

How much do you agree with the actions of (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):

- The police
- The alleged criminals
- The citizens

[$T = 2$] The second culprit attempted to run away, but police chased him and killed him shortly after. The confrontation was the result of an extensive search after the firearm was stolen while officers conducted crowd control at the Bee Centre.

How much do you agree with the actions of (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):

- The police
- The alleged criminals

[$T = 3$] Two firearms were ultimately recovered, though not before the criminals had used them against the police when the standoff began.

How much do you agree with the actions of (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):

- The police
- The alleged criminals

Story Version with Questions

[$T = 0$] You're about to read about an incident involving several police officers and alleged criminals. Before reading, how much do you think you'll agree with the actions of:

(Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree)

- The police
- The alleged criminals

[$T = 1$] Officers were dispatched to deal with an unruly crowd at the Bee Centre on a recent evening. In the midst of attempting to restore order in a chaotic scene, one officer discovered his firearm had been stolen and was in the hands of an unknown person. An investigation ensued and the police discovered the weapon was in the hands of a known criminal.

How much do you agree with the actions of (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):

- The police
- The alleged criminals

[$T = 2$] Concerned citizens were able to provide information to the officers tasked with finding him, and the next day several members of police found the culprit along with an accomplice who possessed an additional firearm. Rather than surrender, the two men began to fire at the police officers.

How much do you agree with the actions of (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):

- The police
- The alleged criminals
- The citizens

[$T = 3$] The police officers returned fire and fatally wounded one of the men. The second suspect tried to flee with both weapons, but officers gave chase and the second suspect was ultimately killed as well.

How much do you agree with the actions of (Strongly agree, Agree, Neither agree nor disagree, Disagree, Strongly disagree):

- The police
- The alleged criminals

E.5 Mediation Analysis

Mediation analysis was done using the `mediation` package in R (Tingley et al., 2014), based on Imai, Keele and Tingley (2010) and Imai, Keele and Yamamoto (2010)’s work on mediation analysis based on a potential outcomes framework. Each estimate was made using a single mediator and 500 simulations. The first assumption of sequential ignorability, that treatment assignment is independent of potential outcomes and mediators, is taken care of by random assignment. However, the second part of sequential ignorability requires that mediators be independent of potential outcomes given treatment assignment and any observed covariates. The results presented below include controls for age, gender, and ethnicity. Mediation analysis with no covariates shows the same patterns, though slightly weaker significance. This is suggestive of this assumption being tenable, but it cannot be fully accepted.

Across the two main outcomes, results in Table 18 and 19 suggest that anxiety about the fate of officers, perspective taking relative to the police officers, and being less skeptical of the officers’ version of the events all consistently partially mediate the effects of storytelling on trust. For saying the police officers will make the right decisions in the future only several measures of entertainment also mediate results. This partial mediation speaks to the theorized mechanisms, however even summing across all questions, a large portion of the treatment effect cannot be accounted for by these measures. This points to some additional explanations for the effect of storytelling on an audience that are not yet accounted for.

Table 18: Mediation Analysis: Right Decision

Mediator	ACME	ADE	Total Effect	Prop. Mediated
Read Another	0.015	0.414***	0.429***	0.031
Think about Other	0.013	0.424***	0.436***	0.027
Hard Focus	0.007	0.419***	0.425***	0.012
Annoyed Delay	0.009	0.415***	0.424***	0.018
Worried Officers	0.022**	0.412***	0.434***	0.047
Worried Criminals	0.004	0.439***	0.443***	0.007
Felt Tense	-0.004	0.440***	0.436***	-0.006
Decisions Police	0.057**	0.364***	0.421***	0.136
Decisions Criminals	0.005	0.414***	0.419***	0.009
Understand Events	0.039***	0.384***	0.422***	0.089
Had Questions	0.008	0.358***	0.367***	0.016
Told Truth	0.055***	0.313***	0.368***	0.146

* p<0.1, ** p<0.05, *** p<0.01. Bootstrap SEs (500 draws).

Table 19: Mediation Analysis: Future Decisions

Mediator	ACME	ADE	Total Effect	Prop. Mediated
Read Another	0.021***	0.334***	0.355***	0.059
Think about Other	0.015**	0.331***	0.346***	0.040
Hard Focus	0.002	0.363***	0.365***	0.002
Annoyed Delay	0.006	0.348***	0.355***	0.015
Worried Officers	0.028**	0.321***	0.349***	0.076
Worried Criminals	0.003	0.330***	0.334***	0.009
Felt Tense	-0.002	0.361***	0.359***	-0.001
Decisions Police	0.035**	0.304***	0.340***	0.102
Decisions Criminals	0.002	0.340***	0.342***	0.003
Understand Events	0.016**	0.323***	0.339***	0.044
Had Questions	0.007	0.235***	0.242***	0.020
Told Truth	0.032**	0.195**	0.227***	0.133

* p<0.1, ** p<0.05, *** p<0.01. Bootstrap SEs (500 draws).

E.6 Figure 1 as a Table

The mean values and standard errors shown in Figure 1 for time periods 0-3 are included in Tables 20 and 21. The same question was asked at each period: how much do you agree

with the actions of [the police / the alleged criminals]. The $t = 4$ result shown in Figure 1 is included in column 1 of Table 17. Finally, Figures 6 and 7 show the p-val of the difference in means for all pairs of means for both outcomes. For instance, the box in the top left corner of Figure 6 shows that the mean of the basic treatment group agreement with police actions in $t = 0$ is significantly different from the mean of the story treatment group agreement with police actions in $t = 3$, with a p-value of 0.02.

Table 20: Agreement with Police Actions by Time Period and Treatment

Time	Basic		Story	
	Mean	SE	Mean	SE
0	0.437	0.059	0.458	0.061
1	0.282	0.081	0.582	0.069
2	0.208	0.083	0.867	0.071
3	0.633	0.075	0.655	0.076

Table 21: Agreement with Criminal Actions by Time Period and Treatment

Time	Basic		Story	
	Mean	SE	Mean	SE
0	0.061	0.065	-0.004	0.065
1	-0.649	0.075	-0.438	0.074
2	-0.657	0.072	-0.871	0.079
3	-0.571	0.077	-0.799	0.079

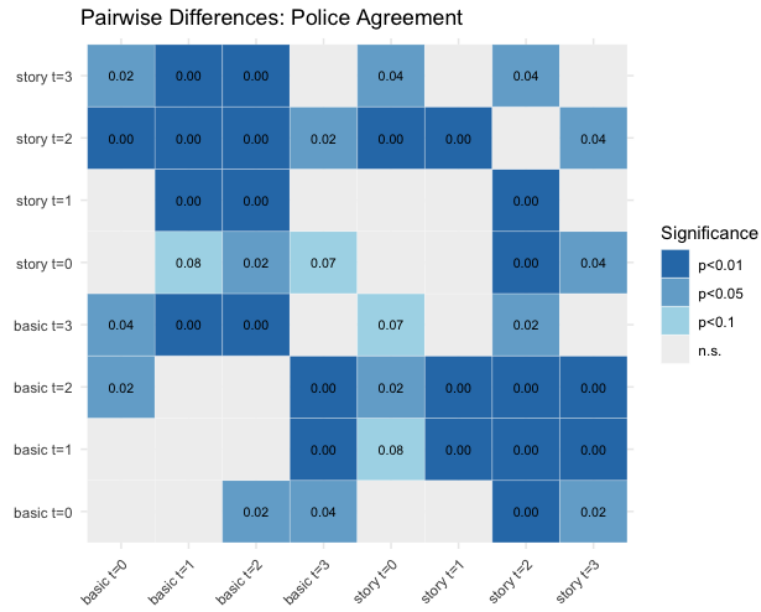


Figure 6: Agreement with Police Actions: Significant Difference Between Means

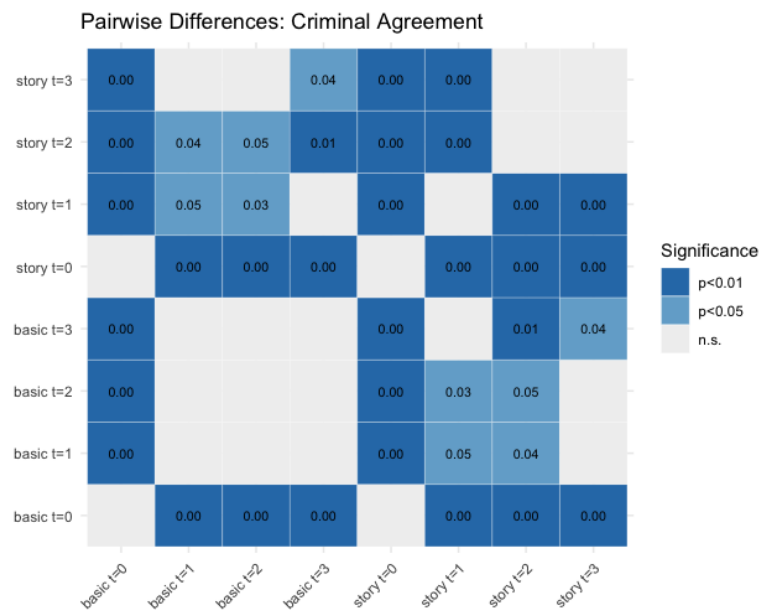


Figure 7: Agreement with Criminal Actions: Significant Difference Between Means

Table 22: Willingness to Provide Information

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>		
	Serious Crime	Misdemeanor	Information
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Follows DCI	0.067 (0.107)	0.235** (0.099)	0.463*** (0.102)
Victim of Crime	-0.240** (0.119)	-0.317*** (0.110)	-0.329*** (0.114)
Stopped by Police	-0.230** (0.107)	-0.061 (0.099)	-0.129 (0.102)
Constant	0.929*** (0.088)	0.455*** (0.081)	0.391*** (0.083)
Observations	727	702	714
R ²	0.015	0.020	0.038
Adjusted R ²	0.011	0.016	0.034

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

E.7 Behavioral Outcomes

E.8 Pre-Analysis Plan

There were 4 main hypotheses included in the pre-analysis plan. For clarity, I will discuss any deviations from the expectations contained therein.

Hypothesis 1: I expect any of the three treatments which vary the structure or information provided to increase perceptions that the officers in the case made the right decisions and will do so in the future. There is no prior belief on whether the story or procedural justice treatment will be most effective, but I do expect the combination to surpass both.

Results: The treatments do indeed increase perceptions that the officers made the right decision and will continue to do so. Though there was no prior on whether the story or procedural justice would be most effective, the results do disagree with the combination being the most effective. Instead, the treatment which combined both elements was equivalent to the story alone; I believe this is due in part to ceiling effects.

Hypothesis 2: I expect the treatments to generate more positive affect towards the police generally in subsequent questions, and result in respondents being more willing to share information.

Results: In contrast to expectations, the different treatments did not change attitudes towards the police generally nor change the willingness to provide information to the police. Citizens who follow the DCI act in the expected way for both outcomes, but it is difficult to attribute this to the account directly.

Table 23: Treatment Effects on Contacting the Police

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	Serious Crime	Misdemeanor Police	Information	Serious Crime Private	Misdemeanor
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Procedural Justice	−0.022 (0.149)	−0.244* (0.143)	0.058 (0.144)	−0.090 (0.164)	−0.147 (0.149)
Story	−0.138 (0.155)	−0.182 (0.148)	0.015 (0.150)	−0.045 (0.170)	−0.052 (0.155)
Justice+Story	0.065 (0.152)	−0.025 (0.145)	0.201 (0.147)	−0.087 (0.167)	−0.107 (0.153)
Constant	0.837*** (0.105)	0.558*** (0.102)	0.481*** (0.102)	0.473*** (0.116)	0.500*** (0.106)
Observations	630	601	617	632	622
R ²	0.003	0.007	0.004	0.001	0.002
Adjusted R ²	−0.002	0.002	−0.001	−0.004	−0.003

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 24: Treatment Effects of Perceptions of Police Generally

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>				
	All	Trust	Justice	Competence	Obey
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Basic	0.014 (0.073)	0.087 (0.093)	0.078 (0.097)	-0.084 (0.093)	-0.098 (0.170)
Procedural Justice	-0.083 (0.073)	0.030 (0.093)	0.096 (0.097)	-0.216** (0.093)	-0.304* (0.169)
Story	-0.101 (0.077)	-0.030 (0.098)	0.025 (0.102)	-0.249** (0.098)	-0.211 (0.179)
Justice+Story	-0.070 (0.074)	0.003 (0.095)	0.046 (0.099)	-0.190** (0.095)	-0.113 (0.174)
Constant	0.046 (0.051)	-0.020 (0.066)	-0.050 (0.068)	0.143** (0.066)	-0.248** (0.120)
Observations	631	631	631	631	631
R ²	0.006	0.003	0.002	0.015	0.006
Adjusted R ²	-0.0003	-0.004	-0.004	0.008	-0.0005
<i>Note:</i>					*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01
<i>Note:</i> Outcomes constitute indices of questions for each concept.					

Hypothesis 3: Reading one of the two story-structured treatments should increase empathy towards police officers (De Graaf et al., 2012) and therefore generate a response to the open-ended question that is more empathetic or less hostile towards the police.

Results:

Respondents were given two statistics: one about the increase in the number of people killed by the police and one about the increase in the number of police killed. They were then asked how they would write about these statistics. Responses were coded by whether the respondent mentioned only the increase in deaths of the police, as a coarse measure of an increase in empathy for the police. Ambiguous responses such as “an increase in police killings”, where it was unclear whether the author meant “by” or “of” were coded 0. Though all coefficients

are in the expected direction, none are significant. This may be an artifact of coding or simply that reading one story was not sufficient to move how people are writing about the police more generally.

Table 25: Summarizing Statistics with Empathy for Police

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>
	Empathetic
PJ	0.058 (0.044)
Story	0.018 (0.045)
PJ+Story	0.025 (0.045)
Constant	0.174*** (0.031)
Observations	637
R ²	0.003
Adjusted R ²	-0.002
<i>Note:</i> *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01	

Hypothesis 4a: I expect that individuals or friends and families’ experiences with the police may act as moderators. That is, stories can have a backlash effect if audiences are invested in the topic and therefore critical (Bilandzic and Busselle, 2013) or skeptical of the source (Escalas, 2007). This may be particularly relevant in this context, where sources have indicated that the contrast between public depictions of police behavior versus the actual lived experience is damaging to trust.²³

Hypothesis 4b: I also expect that whether respondents follow the DCI account link will serve as a moderator. If they are previously exposed to these stories and they are indeed effective, this group may already have a more positive affect towards the police and be less

²³Interview in Nairobi, July 7 and 10, 2023

moved by additional treatment through the survey.

Results: As seen in Appendix E.1 for the most part, direct experiences with the police and already following the DCI do not moderate the effects of a story. There is a single exception, where being stopped by the police in the past or following the DCI made respondents who read a story significantly more likely to say they believe the police will make the right future decisions. This is in the opposite direction as hypothesized, but given the lack of consistency across outcomes and treatments, I expect it to be a statistical anomaly more than anything else. Further, this effect is only observed in the first survey in August 2023. The repeated survey in March 2024 shows no moderation effects.

F U.S. Experiment Treatments

Basic Vignette: DMV

Missing Documents Leads to Failed Registration at the DMV

A DMV employee recently refused service to a customer trying to renew his vehicle registration, saying that he wouldn't be spoken to "like that." This was prompted by the man yelling that the employee was purposefully making the process difficult and wasted his time. The altercation came when he was asked for proof of legal residency like a passport but upon producing a hospital birth certificate, was told it didn't count. Prior to this, the employee had asked for the man's renewal notice, registration card, and license plate number, but the man couldn't supply any of them. After he was refused service, a second DMV employee went after him and told him what documents he needed in order to complete his registration.

Story Vignette: DMV

A Confrontation at the DMV

A DMV employee had a man come to his window to renew his vehicle registration. The employee asked for his renewal notice, but he had left it at home. Then he asked for his registration card, but he had not brought that either. The employee asked did he at least know his license plate number, but he didn't. He asked next for proof of legal residence, such

as a passport. The man said he did have that one and produced a hospital birth certificate. However, the employee had to inform him that a hospital birth certificate didn't count. Before he could continue, the man began yelling at him, saying he made the process too difficult on purpose and wasted his time. The employee finally said that he wouldn't be spoken to like that and he was refusing the man service and closed his window. Another DMV employee went after the man and told him what documents he needed in order to complete his registration.

Basic Vignette: Fire Department

House Damaged After Firefighting Delay

A house recently suffered severe structural damage after a delay in fighting a house fire, which was started by a poorly tended barbeque pit. The delay occurred when a firefighter went into the house without a hose or tools, following two medics who went in before the fire department had arrived. Once inside, the firefighter struggled to find the medics in a smoke-filled house, rapidly heating up from the fire. He ultimately found the medics, and they were able to exit through a window to safety, since the fire had built up behind them. The medics had acted out of fear people were still inside, while the firefighter ran after them knowing they were not wearing full firefighting equipment.

Story Vignette: Fire Department

A Split-Second Decision in a Burning House

Recently, a poorly tended barbeque pit caught a house on fire. The local fire department raced to the scene, to find the house filled with smoke. They learned that two medics had already gone in out of fear there were still people inside the home. One of the firefighters knew that the medics weren't wearing full firefighting equipment and ran after them, without waiting for the delay of tools and hoses. Once inside, it was pitch black and hot as the firefighter searched for the medics, when he realized the fire was building up behind him. Since he had gone in without a hose, all he could do was keep moving forward, when he finally found the medics inside. They all jumped through a window; even as the delay caused severe structural damage, everyone made it out safe.